

Part 2: Social Influence

Chapter 5: Genes, Cultures, and Gender

“By birth, the same; by custom, different.”

—Confucius, The Analects of Confucius

The preceding chapters were about how we think about one another. The next chapters are about how we influence and relate to one another. We will probe social psychology’s central concern: the powers of social influence. What are these unseen social forces that push and pull us? How powerful are they? Research on social influence helps illuminate the invisible strings by which our social worlds move us about. In this chapter, we consider three related topics: biological influences, cultural influences, and gender differences.

For most of human history, fighting wars was the sole province of men. But as cultures have become more open to gender equality, that has changed. The speed of change has also varied from one culture to another. While women in some countries such as Israel have served in combat roles since the 1970s, other countries, such as Pakistan, do not allow women to serve in combat roles today (Army Technology, 2018; Neuman, 2013). Around the world, significantly more men than women serve in militaries, and most countries do not draft women to serve (DeSilver, 2019). In the United States, women first served in military combat roles in 2015, and in 2020 a bipartisan commission recommended that women be required to register for a military draft (Welna, 2020).

Thinking about the roles of women in the military around the world prompts us to consider the questions we explore in this chapter: How much does biology shape who we are? How are we influenced by culture? And how do the influences of biology and culture combine to create similarities and differences among men and women?

HOW ARE WE INFLUENCED BY BIOLOGY?

In many important ways, people from different cultures and of different genders are more alike than different. As members of one great family with common ancestors, we share not only a common biology but also common behavioral tendencies. Everyone sleeps and wakes, feels hunger and thirst, and develops language through identical mechanisms. Everywhere, humans prefer sweet tastes to sour and fear snakes more than sparrows. People across the globe all understand each other’s frowns and smiles.

Humans are intensely social. We join groups, conform, and recognize distinctions of social status. We return favors, punish offenses, and grieve a loved one’s death. As children, beginning at about 8 months of age, we displayed fear of strangers, and as adults, we favor members of our own groups. Confronted by those with dissimilar attitudes or attributes, we react warily or negatively. Anthropologist Donald Brown (1991, 2000) identified several hundred universal behavior and language patterns. To sample among just those beginning with “v,” all human societies have verbs, violence, visiting, and vowels.

Even much of our morality is common across cultures and eras. Before they can walk, babies will display a moral sense by disapproving of what’s wrong or naughty (Bloom, 2010). People old and young, female and male, whether living in Tokyo, Tehran, or Toledo, all say “no” when asked, “If a lethal gas is leaking into a vent and is headed toward a room with seven people, is it okay to push someone into the vent — preventing the gas from reaching the seven but killing the one?” And they are more likely to say “yes” when asked if it’s okay to allow someone to fall into the vent, voluntarily sacrificing one life but saving seven (Hauser, 2006, 2009).

You could drop in anywhere and find humans conversing and arguing, laughing and crying, feasting and dancing, singing and worshiping. Everywhere, humans prefer living with others — in families and communal groups — to living alone.

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Everywhere, the family dramas that entertain us — from Greek tragedies to Chinese fiction to Mexican soap operas — portray similar plots (Dutton, 2006). Similar, too, are adventure stories in which strong and courageous men, supported by wise old people, overcome evil to the delight of beautiful women or threatened children.

Such commonalities define our shared human nature. Although differences draw our attention, ***we're more alike than different***. We're all kin beneath the skin.

Genes, Evolution, and Behavior

The universal behaviors that define human nature arise from our biological similarity. Someone may say, "My ancestors came from Ireland" or "My roots are in China" or "I'm Italian," but if we trace our ancestors back 100,000 or more years, we are all Africans (Shipman, 2003). In response to climate change and the availability of food, early hominids migrated across Africa into Asia, Europe, the Australian subcontinent and, eventually, the Americas. As they adapted to their new environments, early humans developed differences that, measured on anthropological scales, are recent and superficial. Those who stayed in Africa had darker skin pigment — what Harvard psychologist Steven Pinker (2002) called "***sunscreen for the tropics***" — and those who went far north of the equator evolved lighter skins capable of synthesizing vitamin D in less direct sunlight.

We were all Africans recently enough that "there has not been much time to accumulate many new versions of the genes," noted Pinker (2002, p. 143). Indeed, biologists who study our genes have found that we humans — even humans from very different cultures — are strikingly similar, like members of one tribe.

To explain the traits of our species, and all species, the British naturalist Charles Darwin (1859) proposed an evolutionary process. Follow the genes, he advised. Darwin's idea, to which philosopher Daniel Dennett (2005) would give "the gold medal for the best idea anybody ever had," was that ***natural selection*** enables evolution.

The idea, simplified, is this:

- Organisms have many and varied offspring.
- Those offspring compete for survival in their environment.
- Certain biological and behavioral variations increase their chances of survival and reproduction in that environment.
- Those offspring that do survive and reproduce are more likely to pass their genes to ensuing generations.
- Thus, over time, population characteristics may change.

Natural selection implies that certain genes — those producing traits that increased the odds of surviving long enough to reproduce and nurture descendants — became more abundant. In the snowy Arctic environment, for example, genes programming a thick coat of camouflaging white fur have won the genetic competition among bears. Where thick, dark forest is instead the norm, brown and black bears have instead won out.

Natural selection, long an organizing principle of biology, is an important principle for psychology as well. ***Evolutionary psychology*** studies how natural selection also predisposes psychological traits and social behaviors that enhance the preservation and spread of one's genes (Buss & Schmitt, 2019). Humans are the way we are, say evolutionary psychologists, because nature selected those who had advantageous traits — those who, for example, preferred the sweet taste of nutritious, energy-providing foods and who disliked the bitter or sour flavors of toxic foods. Those lacking such preferences were less likely to survive to contribute their genes to posterity.

As mobile gene machines, we carry not only the physical legacy but also the psychological legacy of our ancestors' adaptive preferences. We long for whatever helped our ancestors survive, reproduce, and nurture their offspring to survive and

reproduce. Even negative emotions — anxiety, loneliness, depression, anger — are nature’s way of motivating us to cope with survival challenges. “The purpose of the heart is to pump blood,” noted evolutionary psychologist David Barash (2003). “The brain’s purpose,” he continued, is to direct our organs and our behavior “in a way that maximizes our evolutionary success. That’s it.”

The evolutionary perspective highlights our universal human nature. We not only share certain food preferences, but we also share answers to social questions, such as, Whom should I trust? Whom should I help? When, and with whom, should I mate? Who may dominate me, and whom may I control? Evolutionary psychologists contend that our emotional and behavioral answers to those questions are the same answers that worked for our ancestors.

And what should we fear? Mostly, we fear dangers faced by our distant ancestors. We fear foes, unfamiliar faces, and heights — and thus, possible terrorists, the ethnically different, and airplanes. We fear what’s immediate and sudden more than greater, gradual harms from historically newer threats, such as smoking or climate change.

Because our social tasks are common to people everywhere, humans everywhere tend to agree on the answers. For example, all humans rank others by authority and status. And all have ideas about economic justice (Fiske, 1992). Evolutionary psychologists highlight these universal characteristics that have evolved through natural selection. Cultures, however, provide the specific rules for working out these elements of social life.

Biology and Gender

Visit an elementary school playground at recess and take note of how the boys and girls behave. More of the boys will be running or jumping and might even physically fight with each other when the playground monitor isn’t looking. More of the girls will be playing in small groups and talking to each other.

Here’s what you might wonder: Are these differences due to biology (and thus tied to our evolutionary past) or instead a product of upbringing and culture (and thus something that varies by region and era)? Gender differences are one of the most researched and contentious areas of psychology, so we will use them as our primary example to illustrate how biology and culture interact to make us who we are. We’ll begin by discussing biology as it relates to gender differences.

TERMS FOR STUDYING SEX AND GENDER

First, let’s define some terms. Many people use the terms “sex” and “gender” interchangeably, but in psychology, they refer to different things. **Sex** refers to males and females as two biological categories based on chromosomes, genitals, and secondary sex characteristics such as greater male muscle mass and female breasts.

Gender instead refers to the characteristics people associate with males and females that can be rooted in biology, culture, or both, such as wearing dresses, liking sports, having long hair, wanting more sexual partners, being more physically aggressive, or liking to shop. The differences in behavior on the preschool playground are gendered behaviors; whether each child is biologically male or female is their sex.

Not that long ago, gender and sex were seen as fairly rigid: There were only two sexes, and if someone was born female, she stayed female and usually enacted female gender roles. All of these ideas are now being challenged in one way or another. Until very recently, most cultures delivered a strong message: Everyone must be assigned a sex, and there were only two choices. When an intersex child was born with a combination of male and female sex organs (known as ambiguous genitalia), physicians and the family felt compelled to assign the child a sex by diminishing the ambiguity surgically. Between day and night, there is dusk. Between hot and cold, there is warm. But between male and female there has been, socially speaking, essentially nothing (Sanz, 2017).

That is not as true now. Many doctors now advise that surgery for ambiguous genitalia be postponed until the child expresses whether they identify as a boy or a girl. No matter what their physical appearance, some people identify as **gender fluid** or as **nonbinary**, wishing to be identified as neither male or female (Broussard et al., 2018). The concept has a longer history than you might think; throughout the centuries, many cultures have recognized third genders (Scobey-Thal, 2014). Defining who is male and who is female is also not as clear-cut as it sounds: Do you use chromosomes? Body appearance? Hormone levels? Sometimes these disagree in the same person. In 2019, a court ruled that Olympic runner Caster Semenya, who was born and identifies as female, must take drugs to suppress her naturally higher levels of testosterone, a hormone found in larger quantities among men. Some have argued that Semenya's higher testosterone levels gave her an unfair advantage in competing against other women. This is one of many controversial cases centering around how to define sex categories in women's sports (Burns, 2019).

In addition, some people (about 4 in 1,000 Americans) are **transgender** — those whose sense of being male or female differs from their birth sex (APA, 2012; Meerwijk & Sevelius, 2017). A trans person may feel like a woman in a man's body or a man in a woman's body. Being transgender is not the same as having atypical gender roles; for example, some women have short hair, don't like to shop, and like sports, but still have a fundamental belief that their sex is female. A transgender person who was born female might have any constellation of gender roles but has a fundamental sense of actually being male. When he is ready to transition, he may start living as a man. Some transgender people choose to have surgery to change their sex to fit their identity, but others do not change their bodies but instead present socially as their chosen sex (Testa et al., 2017). For example, Thomas Beatie was born female, lived as a man as an adult, and kept his female reproductive organs, birthing three children (Abbey, 2012).

In this section, we'll explore evolutionary and biological explanations for gender differences. We'll detail the research on gender differences later in the chapter. For now, consider this well-researched difference: **Men think about sex more, masturbate more, and desire a greater number of sexual partners** (Baumeister et al., 2001; Petersen & Hyde, 2011). The question is: **Why?**

GENDER AND MATING PREFERENCES

Evolutionary psychology posits a fairly straightforward answer to this question: Men have stronger sex drives because sex is a cheap investment for men and a big commitment for women. Men and women, note evolutionary psychologists, faced different adaptive challenges when it came to sex and reproduction (Buss, 1995b, 2009). (These ideas are not without controversy; later in this section, we'll explore challenges to this point of view.)

Thus, say evolutionary psychologists, females invest their reproductive opportunities carefully, by looking for signs of resources and commitment. Males compete with other males for chances to win the genetic sweepstakes by sending their genes into the future and thus look for healthy, fertile soil in which to plant their seed. Women want to find men who will help them tend the garden — resourceful and monogamous dads rather than wandering cads. Women seek to reproduce wisely, men widely. Or so the theory goes.

Evolutionary psychology also suggests that those preschool boys fighting with each other on the playground might be in a dress rehearsal for a more serious game. Over much of human history, physically dominant males excelled in gaining access to females, which over generations enhanced male aggression and dominance as the less-aggressive males had fewer chances to reproduce. The genes that may have helped Montezuma II to become Aztec king were also given to his offspring, with the help of the 4,000 women in his harem (Wright, 1998). Genghis Khan, who led invasions that brought much of Asia under his empire, is an ancestor of approximately 1 in 200 men worldwide (Zerjal, 2003). Even today, men are more aggressive toward other men when they are thinking about dating and mating (Ainsworth & Maner, 2012, 2014). Underlying all these presumptions is a principle: **Nature selects traits that help send one's genes into the future.**

Little of this process is conscious. Few people in the throes of passion stop to think, “I want to give my genes to posterity.” Rather, say evolutionary psychologists, our natural yearnings are our genes’ way of making more genes. Emotions execute evolution’s dispositions, much as hunger executes the body’s need for nutrients

“Every living human is a descendant of a long line of successful maters,” says evolutionary psychologist David Buss (Kluger, 2020). “We’ve adapted to pick certain types of mates and to fulfill the desires of the opposite sex.” And that, evolutionary psychologists believe, helps explain not only male aggression but also the differing sexual attitudes and behaviors of females and males.

Evolutionary psychology also predicts that women will prefer men with the resources to help with the labor-intensive and expensive process of raising a child to full adulthood. Thus, men will strive to offer what women will desire — external resources and physical protection. Male peacocks strut their feathers; male humans, their abs, Audis, and assets (Sundie et al., 2011). In one experiment, teen males rated “having lots of money” as more important after they were put alone in a room with a teen female (Roney, 2003). In one Cardiff, Wales, study, men rated a woman as equally attractive whether she was at the wheel of a humble Ford Fiesta or a swanky Bentley; women found the man more attractive if he was in the luxury car (Dunn & Searle, 2010). **“Male achievement is ultimately a courtship display,”** said Glenn Wilson (1994).

And what do men want? Evolutionary psychologists posit that men favor fertility in women, generally signaled by a youthful and healthy appearance. Men with these preferences, they note, were the most likely to have many offspring. That may not be the conscious desire of most men today, but their evolutionary history unconsciously pulls them to prefer these characteristics. Evolutionary psychology studies note that gender differences in mate preferences are very large compared to most other psychological sex differences (Conroy-Beam et al., 2015). They are also fairly universal across cultures:

- Studies in 45 cultures, from Australia to Zambia, reveal that men everywhere feel attracted to women whose physical features, such as youthful faces and forms, suggest fertility. Women everywhere feel attracted to men whose wealth, power, and ambition promise resources for protecting and nurturing offspring (Walter et al., 2020). But there are gender similarities, too: Whether residing on an Indonesian island or in urban São Paulo, both women and men desire kindness, love, and mutual attraction.
- Men everywhere tend to be most attracted to women whose age and features suggest peak fertility. For teen boys, this is a woman several years older than themselves. For men in their mid-20s, it’s women their own age. For older men, it’s younger women; the older the man, the greater the age difference he prefers when selecting a mate (Kenrick et al., 2009). This pattern appears worldwide, in European singles ads, Indian marital ads, online dating, and marriage records from the Americas, Africa, and the **Philippines** (Singh, 1993; Singh & Randall, 2007), and — though to a somewhat lesser extent — among gays and lesbians, with many gay men preferring younger partners and lesbian women preferring older partners (Conway et al., 2015). **Men married to physically attractive wives reported higher marital satisfaction, whereas husbands’ physical attractiveness had little impact on wives’ satisfaction** (Meltzer et al., 2014). Again, say the evolutionary psychologists, we see that natural selection predisposes men to feel attracted to female features associated with fertility.
- Monthly fertility also matters. Women’s behaviors, scents, and voices provide subtle clues to their ovulation, which men can detect (Haselton & Gildersleeve, 2011). When at peak fertility, women express greater apprehensiveness of potentially threatening men and greater ability to detect men’s sexual orientation (Gildersleeve et al., 2014). They also behave more flirtatiously with men who are confident and socially dominant (Cantu et al., 2014).

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Reflecting on the mate preference findings, Buss (1999) reported feeling somewhat astonished “that men and women across the world differ in their mate preferences in precisely the ways predicted by the evolutionists. Just as our fears of snakes, heights, and spiders provide a window for viewing the survival hazards of our evolutionary ancestors, our mating desires provide a window for viewing the resources our ancestors needed for reproduction. We all carry with us today the desires of our successful forebears.” Or as William Faulkner wrote, “*The past is never dead. In fact, it’s not even past.*” Our ancestral past lives on, in us.

Gender and Hormones

Evolutionary psychology may explain why sex differences are rooted in biological processes, but it doesn’t explain how. One way that biology influences sex differences is through hormones, chemicals in our bodies that can influence behavior and mood. For example, men on average have a higher level of testosterone, a hormone linked to dominance and aggression.

Hormones are important because genes by themselves cannot be the source of gender differences: Genetically, males and females differ on only a single chromosome out of 46, and the Y (male) chromosome is distinguished primarily by one gene. That gene directs the formation of the testicles, which begin to secrete testosterone. Girls exposed to excess testosterone during fetal development tend to exhibit more tomboyish play behavior than other girls (Hines, 2004) and resemble males in their career preferences, with a greater interest in things than people (Beltz et al., 2011). When asked to rotate objects, genetic males insensitive to testosterone show brain activity more typical of females, as their brains were not exposed to as much testosterone prenatally (Van Hemmen et al., 2016). Overall, children exposed to more testosterone in the womb exhibit the psychological pattern more typical of males, including less eye contact, lower language skill, and less empathy (Auyeung et al., 2013).

The gender gap in aggression also seems influenced by testosterone. In various animals, administering testosterone heightens aggressiveness. In humans, violent male criminals, on average, have higher than normal testosterone levels; so do National Football League players, boisterous fraternity members, and college men involved in a sport (Dabbs, 2000; Reed & Meggs, 2017). Moreover, for both humans and monkeys, the gender difference in aggression appears early in life (before culture has much effect) and wanes as testosterone levels decline during adulthood. However, testosterone levels also fluctuate depending on the situation: **Acting aggressively can increase testosterone in men** (Geniole et al., 2020), and **acting compassionately** (such as while taking care of a baby) **can decrease it** (Gettler et al., 2011).

As people mature to middle age and beyond, a curious thing happens. Women become more assertive and self-confident, and men become more empathic and less domineering (Kasen et al., 2006; Pratt et al., 1990). Hormone changes are one possible explanation for the shrinking gender differences. Role demands are another. Some speculate that during courtship and early parenthood, social expectations lead both sexes to emphasize traits that enhance their roles. While courting, providing, and protecting, men play up their macho sides and forgo their needs for interdependence and nurturance (Gutmann, 1977). While dating or rearing young children, young women restrain their impulses to assert and be independent. As men and women graduate from these early adult roles, they supposedly express more of their restrained tendencies. Each becomes more **androgynous** — capable of both assertiveness and nurturance.

Reflections on Evolutionary Psychology

Without disputing natural selection — nature’s process of selecting physical and behavioral traits that enhance gene survival — critics see a problem with evolutionary explanations. Evolutionary psychologists sometimes start with a finding (such as the male-female difference in sexual initiative) and then work backward to construct an explanation for it. As biologists Paul Ehrlich and Marcus Feldman (2003) have pointed out, the evolutionary theorist can hardly lose when employing hindsight. Today’s evolutionary psychology is like yesterday’s Freudian psychology, say such critics: Either theory can be retrofitted to whatever happens.

The way to overcome the hindsight bias is to imagine things turning out otherwise. Let's try it. Imagine that women were stronger and more physically aggressive than men. "But of course!" someone might say, "all the better for protecting their young." *And if human males were never known to have extramarital affairs, might we not see the evolutionary wisdom behind their fidelity?* There is more to bringing offspring to maturity than merely depositing sperm, so men and women both gain by investing jointly in their children. Males who are loyal to their mates and offspring are more likely to see their young survive to perpetuate their genes. Monogamy also increases men's certainty of paternity. (These are, in fact, evolutionary explanations — again based on hindsight — for why humans, and certain other species whose young require a heavy parental investment, tend to pair off and be monogamous).

Evolutionary psychologists argue that hindsight plays no less a role in cultural explanations: Why do women and men differ? Because their culture *socializes* their behavior! When people's roles vary across time and place, "culture" describes those roles better than it explains them. And far from being mere hindsight conjecture, say evolutionary psychologists, their field is an empirical science that tests evolutionary predictions with data from animal behavior, cross-cultural observations, and hormonal and genetic studies. As in many scientific fields, observations inspire a theory that generates new, testable predictions. The predictions alert us to unnoticed phenomena and allow us to confirm, refute, or revise the theory.

HOW ARE WE INFLUENCED BY CULTURE?

Imagine getting on a plane tonight, settling down to sleep, and waking up tomorrow in another country. You immediately notice that people are speaking a different language, greeting each other in different ways, and wearing different clothing than in the country you inhabited just the day before. For all of our similarities as humans, we also exhibit a breathtaking diversity in the way we live our lives around the world.

We'll begin by discussing cultural influences in general and then, as we did in the previous section on biology, will use gender differences as a vehicle to explore cultural influences on behavior.

Culture and Behavior

We humans have been selected not only for big brains and biceps but also for culture. We come prepared to learn language and to bond and cooperate with others in securing food, caring for the young, and protecting ourselves. Perhaps our most important similarity, the hallmark of our species, is our capacity to learn and adapt. Our genes enable an adaptive human brain — a cerebral hard drive that receives the culture's software. Evolution has prepared us to live creatively in a changing world and to thrive in environments from equatorial jungles to Arctic ice fields. Compared with bees, birds, and bulldogs, nature has humans on a looser genetic leash. Ironically, our shared human biology enables our cultural diversity. It enables those in one culture to value promptness, welcome frankness, or accept premarital sex, whereas those in another culture do not. As social psychologist Roy Baumeister (2005, p. 29) observed, "Evolution made us for culture." (See "Focus On: The Cultural Animal.")

It's important to understand that biology and culture are not two completely separate influences. More often than not, they interact to produce the diversity of behavior you see around you. ***Genes are not fixed blueprints; their expression depends on the environment***, much as the taste of tea is not "expressed" until meeting a hot water environment. One study of New Zealand young adults revealed a gene variation that put people at risk for depression, but only if they had also experienced major life stresses such as their parents' divorce (Caspi et al., 2003). Neither the stress nor the gene alone produced depression, but the two interacting did. Such findings have spawned the science of ***epigenetics***, which considers how environments modify gene expression.

epigenetics

The study of environmental influences on gene expression that occur without DNA change.

focus

ON

The Cultural Animal

We are, said Aristotle, the social animal. We humans have at least one thing in common with wolves and bees: We flourish by organizing ourselves into groups and working together.

But more than that, noted Roy Baumeister, we are — as he labeled us in the title of his 2005 book — *The Cultural Animal*. Humans more than other animals harness the power of culture to make life better. “Culture is a better way of being social,” he wrote. We have culture to thank for our communication through language, our driving safely on one side of the road, our eating fruit in winter, and our use of money to pay for our cars and fruit. Culture facilitates our survival and reproduction, and nature has blessed us with a brain that, like no other, enables culture.

Other animals show the rudiments of culture and language. Monkeys who learn new food-washing techniques then pass them to future generations. And chimps exhibit a modest capacity for language. But no species can accumulate progress across generations as smartly as humans. Your nineteenth-century ancestors had no cars, no indoor plumbing, no electricity, no air conditioning, no internet, no smartphones, no Facebook pages, and no

Post-it notes — all things for which you can thank culture. Intelligence enables innovation, and culture enables dissemination — the transmission of information and innovation across time and place.

The division of labor is “another huge and powerful advantage of culture,” noted Baumeister. Few of us grow food or build shelter, yet nearly everyone reading this book enjoys food and shelter. Indeed, books themselves are a tribute to the division of labor enabled by culture. Although only two lucky people’s names go on this book’s cover, the product is actually the work of a coordinated team of researchers, reviewers, assistants, and editors. Books and other media disseminate knowledge, providing the engine of progress.

“Culture is what is special about human beings,” concluded Baumeister. “Culture helps us to become something much more than the sum of our talents, efforts, and other individual blessings. In that sense, culture is the greatest blessing of all. . . . Alone we would be but cunning brutes, at the mercy of our surroundings. Together, we can sustain a system that enables us to make life progressively better for ourselves, our children, and those who come after.”

Nature predisposes us to learn whatever culture we are born into. The cultural perspective highlights human adaptability. People’s “natures are alike,” said Confucius; “it is their habits that carry them far apart.” And we are still far apart, noted world culture researchers Ronald Inglehart and Christian Welzel (2005). Despite increasing education, “we are not moving toward a uniform global culture: cultural convergence is not taking place. A society’s cultural heritage is remarkably enduring” (p. 46).

CULTURAL DIVERSITY

The diversity of our languages, customs, and expressive behaviors confirms that much of our behavior is socially programmed, not hardwired. The genetic leash is long. As sociologist Ian Robertson (1987) has noted:

Americans eat oysters but not snails. The French eat snails but not locusts. The Zulus eat locusts but not fish. The Jews eat fish but not pork. The Hindus eat pork but not beef. The Russians eat beef but not snakes. The Chinese eat snakes but not people. The Jalé of New Guinea find people delicious. (p. 67)

If we all lived as homogeneous ethnic groups in separate regions of the world, as some people still do, cultural diversity would be less relevant to our daily living. In Japan, where 98.5% of people are Japanese (CIA, 2017), internal cultural differences are minimal. In contrast, cultural differences abound in New York City, where more than one-third of the 9 million residents are foreign born.

Increasingly, cultural diversity surrounds us. More and more, we live in a global village, connected to our fellow villagers by electronic social networks, jumbo jets, and international trade. The mingling of cultures is nothing new. “American” jeans were invented in 1872 by German immigrant Levi Strauss by combining “Genes”, the trouser style of Genoese sailors, with denim cloth from a French town (Legrain, 2003).

Confronting another culture is sometimes a startling experience. American males may feel uncomfortable when Middle Eastern heads of state greet the U.S. president with a kiss on the cheek. A German student, accustomed to speaking to “Herr Professor” only on rare occasions, considers it strange that at my institution, most faculty office doors are open and students stop by freely. An Iranian student on her first visit to an American McDonald’s restaurant fumbles around in her paper bag looking for the eating utensils until she sees the other customers eating their french fries with, of all things, their hands. In many areas of the globe, your best manners and mine are serious breaches of etiquette. Foreigners visiting Japan often struggle to master the rules of the social game — when to take off their shoes, how to pour the tea, when to give and open gifts, how to act toward someone higher or lower in the social hierarchy.

Migration and refugee evacuations are mixing cultures more than ever. “East is East and West is West, and never the twain shall meet,” wrote the nineteenth-century British author Rudyard Kipling. But today, East and West, and North and South, meet all the time. Italy is home to many Albanians, Germany to Turks, England — where Mohammed in its various spellings is now the most common boy’s name (Cohen, 2011) — to Pakistanis. The result is both friendship and conflict. One in 5 Canadians and 1 in 8 Americans are immigrants. As we work, play, and live with people from diverse cultural backgrounds, it helps to understand how our cultures influence us and how our cultures differ. ***In a conflict-laden world, achieving peace requires appreciation for both our genuine differences and our deep similarities.***

NORMS: EXPECTED BEHAVIOR

As etiquette rules illustrate, all cultures have their accepted ideas about appropriate behavior. We often view these social expectations, or norms, as a negative force that imprisons people in a blind effort to perpetuate tradition. Norms do restrain and control us — so successfully and so subtly that we hardly sense their existence. ***Like fish in the ocean, we are all so immersed in our cultures that we must leap out of them to understand their influence.*** “When we see other Dutch people behaving in what foreigners would call a Dutch way,” noted Dutch psychologists Willem Koomen and Anton Dijksterhuis (1997), “we often do not realize that the behavior is typically Dutch.”

There is no better way to learn the norms of our native culture than to visit another culture and see that its members do things that way, whereas we do them this way. When living in Scotland, I acknowledged to my children that, yes, Europeans eat meat with the fork facing down in the left hand. “But we Americans consider it good manners to cut the meat and then transfer the fork to the right hand. I admit it’s inefficient. But it’s the way we do it.”

To those who don’t accept them, such norms may seem arbitrary and confining. To most in the Western world, the Muslim woman’s head covering (known as the hijab) seems arbitrary and confining, but not to most in Muslim cultures. The Muslim women in my classes believe the hijab encourages men to see them as people rather than as sexual objects. Just as a stage play moves smoothly when the actors know their lines, so social behavior occurs smoothly when people know what to expect. ***Norms grease the social machinery.*** In unfamiliar situations, when the norms may be unclear, we monitor others’ behavior and adjust our own accordingly.

Cultures vary in their norms for expressiveness, punctuality, rule breaking, and personal space. Consider the following:

INDIVIDUAL CHOICES Cultures vary in how much they emphasize the individual self (individualistic cultures) versus others and the society (collectivistic cultures). As a result, Western (usually individualistic) countries allow people more latitude in making their own decisions. When I was in college, my Pakistani-American friend wanted to go to graduate school to study Latin. Her parents insisted she go to medical school, saying they would cut off their financial support if she did not. Having grown up in the United States, I was shocked that her parents would tell her what profession to pursue, but in collectivistic cultures, this type of obedience to one’s parents is more widely accepted (Lum et al., 2016).

Differences rooted in individualism and collectivism also appear on social media sites. People in collectivistic countries are more likely to use social media to promote group belonging, such as by commenting on others’ posts. Those in

individualistic countries, however, are more likely to use social media for self-expression, such as posting about their thoughts and activities (Hong & Na, 2018).

EXPRESSIVENESS AND PUNCTUALITY To someone from a relatively formal northern European culture, a person whose roots are in an expressive Latin American culture may seem “warm, charming, inefficient, and time-wasting.” Latin American business executives who arrive late for a dinner engagement may be mystified by the irritation of their time-obsessed North American counterparts. To the Latin American person, the northern European may seem “efficient, cold, and overconcerned with time” (Beaulieu, 2004; Triandis, 1981). And they might be right: Northern Europeans walk faster on public streets than those in Latin America, and northern European bank clocks are more accurate (Levine & Norenzayan, 1999). North American tourists in Japan may wonder about the lack of eye contact from passing pedestrians. (See “Research Close-Up: Passing Encounters, East and West.”)

research CLOSE-UP: Passing Encounters, East and West

On my [DM’s] Midwestern American campus and in my town, sidewalk passersby routinely glance and smile at one another. In Britain and China, where I have spent time, I have rarely observed such microinteractions. To a European, our greeting passing strangers might seem a bit silly and disrespectful of privacy; to a Midwesterner, avoiding eye contact — what sociologists have called “civil inattention” — might seem aloof.

To quantify the culture difference in pedestrian interactions, an international team led by Miles Patterson and Yuichi Iizuka (2007) conducted a simple field experiment both in the United States and in Japan with the unwitting participation of more than 1,000 pedestrians. Their procedure illustrates how social psychologists sometimes conduct unobtrusive research in natural settings (Patterson, 2008). As Figure 1 depicts, an accomplice (an accomplice of the experimenter) would initiate one of three behaviors when within about 12 feet of an approaching pedestrian on an uncrowded sidewalk: (1) avoidance (looking straight ahead), (2) glancing at the person for less than a second, and (3) looking at the person and smiling. A trailing observer would then record the pedestrian’s reaction. Did the pedestrian glance at the accomplice? Smile? Nod? Verbally greet the accomplice? (The order of the three conditions was randomized and unknown to the trailing observer, ensuring that the person recording the data was “blind” to the experimental condition.)

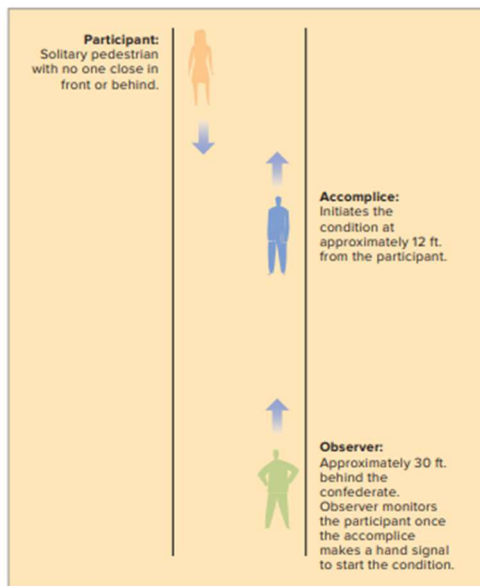


FIGURE 1
Illustration of Passing Encounter

Source: Patterson, M. L., Iizuka, Y., Tubbs, M., Ansel, J., Tsutsumi, M., & Anson, J. (2007).

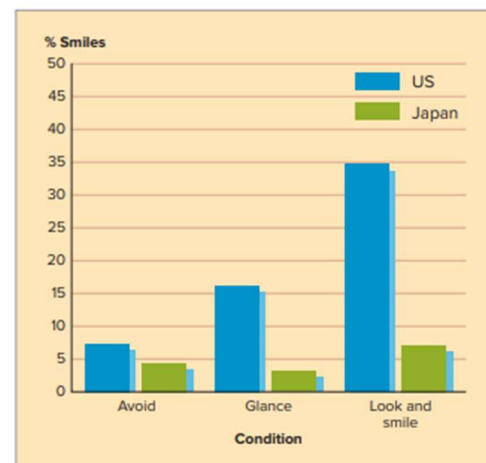


FIGURE 2
American and Japanese Pedestrian Responses, by Condition

Source: Adapted from Patterson, M. L., Iizuka, Y., Tubbs, M., Ansel, J., Tsutsumi, M., & Anson, J. (2007).

As you might expect, the pedestrians were more likely to look at someone who looked at them and to smile at, nod to, or greet someone who also smiled at them. This was especially so when that someone was female rather than male. But as Figure 2 shows, the culture differences were nevertheless striking. As the research team expected, in view of Japan’s greater respect for privacy and cultural reserve when interacting with outgroups, Americans were much more likely to smile at, nod to, or greet the accomplice.

In Japan, they conclude, “there is little pressure to reciprocate the smile of the accomplice because there is no relationship with the accomplice and no obligation to respond.”

RULE-FOLLOWING Norms and rule-following are especially important in traditional, collectivistic cultures, where violating norms is punished most harshly when others are harmed (Feinberg et al., 2019). However, rules can go beyond harm protection to promoting group sameness and harmony. In one study, Koreans (compared to Americans) were more likely to avoid co-workers who were vegetarians, perhaps because this is a nonnormative choice. To most Americans, being a vegetarian is a personal preference; to a Korean, it signals standing out from the group and is thus undesirable (Kinias et al., 2014). Many collectivistic cultures promote the belief that human suffering — such as contracting a disease — is caused by violating social norms (Sullivan et al., 2012). **Collectivistic cultures are more likely to stigmatize people seen as different**, whether through identity (gays and lesbians, immigrants) or behavior (heavy drinkers, drug addicts [Shin et al., 2013]).

Collectivistic or “tight” cultures may have developed strong norms because they were historically more likely to experience threats such as wars or famines (Gelfand et al., 2011). Collectivistic cultures are also more likely to have experienced another threat: frequent outbreaks of infectious diseases. During outbreaks, citizens must follow specific rules, such as physical distancing, hand washing, and wearing masks in public. A culture with a strong emphasis on rules may adapt more easily to these situations. In contrast, individualistic cultures have historically had less experience with disease outbreaks, and place less emphasis on following rules (Grossmann & Varnum, 2015; Morand & Walther, 2018). This might be one reason why the citizens of individualistic countries such as the United States found it difficult to adapt to the restrictions imposed during the COVID-19 pandemic: Americans were not used to being told what to do. Slowly, however, mask-wearing and physical distancing became a norm in many areas of the country — one that residents of more collectivistic countries adopted without question early in the pandemic.

PERSONAL SPACE *Personal space* is a sort of portable bubble or buffer zone that we like to maintain between ourselves and others. As the situation changes, the bubble varies in size. With strangers, most Americans maintain a fairly large personal space, keeping 4 feet or more between us. On uncrowded buses or in restrooms or libraries, we protect our space and respect others’ space. We let friends come closer (Novelli et al., 2010). Norms for personal space changed suddenly with the advent of social distancing during the COVID-19 pandemic, when people were asked to stay 6 feet apart from each other in public.

Individuals differ: Some people prefer more personal space than others (Perry et al., 2013). Groups differ, too: Adults maintain more distance than do children. Men keep more distance from one another than women do. For reasons unknown, **cultures near the equator prefer less distance and more touching and hugging**. Thus, the British and the Scandinavians prefer more distance than the French and the Arabs; North Americans prefer more space than Latin Americans (Sorokowska et al., 2017).

Peer-Transmitted Culture

Cultures, like ice cream, come in many flavors. On Wall Street, men mostly wear suits, and women often wear skirts and dresses. In Scotland, many men wear pleated skirts (kilts) as formal dress. In some equatorial cultures, men and women wear virtually nothing at all. How are such traditions preserved across generations?

The prevailing assumption is what Judith Rich Harris (1998, 2007) called *The Nurture Assumption*: **Parental nurture, the way parents bring their children up, governs who their children become**. On that much, Freudians and behaviorists - and your next-door neighbor— agree. Comparing the extremes of loved children and abused children suggests that parenting does matter. Moreover, children do acquire many of their values, including their political affiliation and religious faith, at home. But if children’s personalities likewise are molded by parental example and nurture, then children who grow up in the same families should be noticeably alike, shouldn’t they?

That presumption is refuted by the most astonishing, agreed-upon, and dramatic finding of developmental psychology: Growing up in the same family makes very little difference — at least in personality traits.

The evidence from studies of twins and biological and adoptive siblings indicates that genetic influences explain roughly 40% of individual variations in personality traits (Vukasović & Bratko, 2015). ***Shared environmental influences — including the shared home influence — account for only 0 to 1% of their personality differences.*** So what accounts for the rest? Much of it is **peer influence**, Harris argued. What children and teens care about most is not what their parents think but what their friends think. ***Children and youths learn their culture — their games, their musical tastes, their accents, even their dirty words — mostly from peers.*** Most teens therefore talk, act, and dress more like their peers than their parents. In hindsight, that makes sense. It's their peers with whom they play and eventually will work and mate. Consider:

- Preschoolers will often refuse to try a certain food despite parents' urgings — until they are put at a table with a group of children who like it.
- Having friends who text while driving triples the odds of your doing so (Trivedi et al., 2017).
- Young immigrant children whose families are transplanted into foreign cultures usually grow up preferring the language and norms of their new peer culture. A young child who moves with her family from China to the United States will speak English with an American accent — even if her parents never learn English or have heavy accents. Youth may “code-switch” when they step back into their homes, but their hearts and minds are with their peer groups. Likewise, deaf children of hearing parents who attend schools for the deaf usually leave their parents' culture and assimilate into deaf culture.

Therefore, if we left a group of children with their same schools, neighborhoods, and peers but switched the parents around, said Harris (1996) in taking her argument to its limits, they “would develop into the same sort of adults.” Parents have an important influence, but it's substantially indirect; parents help define the schools, neighborhoods, and peers that directly influence whether their children become delinquent, use drugs, or get pregnant. Moreover, children often take their cues from slightly older children, who get their cues from older youth, who take theirs from young adults in the parents' generation.

The links of influence from parental group to child group are loose enough that the cultural transmission is never perfect. And in both human and primate cultures, change comes from the young. When one monkey discovers a better way of washing food or when people develop a new idea about fashion or gender roles, the innovation usually comes from the young and is more readily embraced by younger adults. Thus, cultural traditions continue; yet cultures change.

Cultural Similarity

Thanks to human adaptability, cultures differ. Yet beneath the veneer of cultural differences, cross-cultural psychologists see “***an essential universality***” (Lonner, 1980). ***How much we are similar is usually larger than how much we differ*** (Hanel et al., 2019). As members of one species, the processes that underlie our differing behaviors are much the same everywhere (Figure 3).

People everywhere have some common norms for friendship. From studies conducted in Britain, Italy, Hong Kong, and Japan, Michael Argyle and Monika Henderson (1985) noted several cultural variations in the norms that define the role of friend. For example, in Japan it's especially important not to embarrass a friend with public criticism. But there are also some apparently universal norms: respect the friend's privacy; make eye contact while talking; don't divulge things said in confidence. Across 75 nations, the most valued traits were honesty, fairness, kindness, good judgment, and curiosity — nearly all crucial virtues for friendships and relationships (McGrath, 2015).

Around the world, people describe others with between two and five universal personality dimensions (McCrae & Costa, 2008; Saucier et al., 2014). Evaluating others as good or bad appears across almost all cultures and languages. All cultures have norms, so all cultures evaluate how well others follow those norms (Saucier et al., 2014).



FIGURE 3

Words used to express positive emotion in (a) India and (b) the United States

In a study of the language of Facebook users, positive emotion was expressed in similar ways in India (top) and the United States (bottom), with a few cultural differences (such as the greater use of "thanks" in India).

(a-b) Source: Kern, M. L., & Sap, M. (2015).

Likewise, there are five universal dimensions of social beliefs (Leung & Bond, 2004). Across 38 countries, people varied in cynicism, social complexity, reward for application, spirituality, and fate control (Figure 4). People's adherence to these social beliefs appears to guide their living. Cynics express lower life satisfaction and favor assertive influence tactics and right-wing politics. Those who believe in hard work ("reward for application") are inclined to invest themselves in study, planning, and competing.

FIGURE 4
Leung and Bond's
Universal Social Belief
Dimensions

The Big Five Social Beliefs	Sample Questionnaire Item
Cynicism	"Powerful people tend to exploit others."
Social complexity	"One has to deal with matters according to the specific circumstances."
Reward for application	"One will succeed if he/she really tries."
Spirituality	"Religious faith contributes to good mental health."
Fate control	"Fate determines one's success and failures."

Wherever people form status hierarchies, they also talk to higher-status people in the respectful way they often talk to strangers. And they talk to lower-status people in the more familiar, first-name way they speak to friends (Brown, 1965, 1987; Kroger & Wood, 1992). Patients call their physician "Dr. So and So"; the physician may reply using the patients' first names. Students and professors typically address one another in a similarly nonmutual way.

Most languages have two forms of the English pronoun "you": a respectful form and a familiar form (for example, Sie and du in German, vous and tu in French, usted and tu in Spanish). People typically use the familiar form with intimates and subordinates, with close friends and family members, but also in speaking to children and pets. A German adolescent receives a boost when strangers begin addressing him or her as "Sie" instead of "du."

Culture and Gender

In the first part of this chapter, we considered biological and evolutionary explanations for why men and women differ. Yet biology is not the entire story: What it means to be a man or woman, boy or girl, differs from one culture to another.

We can see the shaping power of culture in ideas about how men and women should behave. And we can see culture in the disapproval men and women endure when they violate those expectations (Kite, 2001). In countries everywhere, girls spend more time helping with housework and child care, and boys spend more time in unsupervised play (Edwards, 1991; Kalenkoski et al., 2009; United Nations, 2010). Even in contemporary, dual-career, North American marriages, men do most of the household repairs, and women arrange the child care (Bianchi et al., 2000; BLS, 2017; Fisher et al., 2007). Such behavior expectations for males and females — of who should cook, wash dishes, hunt game, and lead companies and countries — define **gender roles**.

Does culture construct these gender roles? Or do gender roles merely reflect men's and women's natural behavior tendencies? The variety of gender roles across cultures and over time shows that culture indeed helps construct our gender roles.

Gender Roles Vary with Culture

Despite gender role inequalities, the majority of the world's people would ideally like to see more parallel male and female roles. A 2010 Pew Global Attitudes survey asked 25,000 people whether life was more satisfying when both spouses work

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and share childcare or when women stay home and care for the children while the husband provides. In 21 of 22 countries, most chose both spouses working.

However, large country-to-country differences exist. Pakistanis disagreed with the world majority opinion by 4 to 1, whereas the Spanish concurred by 13 to 1. When jobs are scarce, should men have more right to a job? Yes, agreed about 1 in 8 people in Britain, Spain, and the United States — and 4 in 5 people in Indonesia, Pakistan, and Nigeria (Pew, 2010).

Overall, observed Wendy Wood and Alice Eagly (2000, 2002), ***culture often reinforces gender roles that may have originated with biological demands***. Women gathered because they needed to stay close to home; men hunted because they didn't. Cultural differences may also begin with one difference between men and women influencing many others. Men's greater physical strength may have also led to patriarchy being the most common system. Virtually all societies have men in positions of social power and assign different roles to men and women. As a consequence, similarities across cultures might represent male social power rather than evolved differences.

Gender Roles Vary over Time

In the past half century — a thin slice of our long history — gender roles have changed dramatically. In 1938, just 1 in 5 Americans approved “of a married woman earning money in business or industry if she has a husband capable of supporting her.” By 1996, 4 in 5 approved (Niemi et al., 1989; NORC, 1996). Among U.S. 12th graders in the late 1970s, 59% agreed that “A preschooler is likely to suffer if the mother works,” but by 2017 only 16% agreed (Donnelly et al., 2015; Meich et al., 2018). While the majority of Americans in the 1950s saw men as more competent than women, a sizable majority now view women as more competent (Eagly et al., 2020).

Behavioral changes have accompanied this attitude shift. In 1965 the Harvard Business School had never granted a degree to a woman. In its 2021 class, 43% of students were women (Harvard Business School, 2020). From 1960 to 2018, women rose from 6% to 51% of U.S. medical students and from 3% to 52% of law students (AAMC, 2019; ABA, 2019; Hunt, 2000); thus, the majority of those studying to be doctors and lawyers are now women. Role models may be a crucial catalyst for such shifts. When a law in India reserved leadership positions in some villages for women, girls became more likely to aspire to higher education and careers compared to the villages without female role models (Beaman et al., 2012).

Things have changed at home, too. In the mid-1960s American married women devoted *seven times* as many hours to housework as did their husbands (Bianchi et al., 2000). By 2015 the gender gap had shrunk yet persisted: 22% of men and 50% of women did housework in an average day, with women averaging 2.3 hours on their housework days and men 1.4 hours on theirs (BLS, 2016). The time fathers spent caring for children has tripled since 1965, though mothers in 2018 still spent twice as much time on child care as fathers (BLS, 2020). The number of stay-at-home dads has doubled since 1989, and just as many dads as moms in 2015 said that parenting was extremely important to their identity (Livingston & Parker, 2019).

The trends toward more gender equality appear across many cultures; for example, women are increasingly represented in the legislative bodies of most nations (Inglehart & Welzel, 2005; IPU, 2017). Such changes, across cultures and over a remarkably short time, signal that evolution and biology do not render gender roles unchangeable: Time also bends the genders. Progressive gender roles may also bend cultures toward peace: Societies with more gender equality are less likely to engage in war and are less violent (Caprioli & Boyer, 2001; Melander et al., 2005).

Overall, gender roles have shifted considerably over the decades, yet many gender differences still persist. The interplay of biology and culture will continue, and in the decades to come, gender roles may continue to evolve.

HOW ARE FEMALES AND MALES ALIKE AND DIFFERENT?

As we've seen, nowhere is the interplay of biology and culture more evident than in the differences between men and women. So, what are those differences — not the popular conceptions or stereotypes, but the actual differences found in research?

First, let's consider how men and women are similar. "Of the 46 chromosomes in the human genome, 45 are unisex," noted Judith Rich Harris (1998). Females and males are therefore similar in many physical traits and developmental milestones during infancy, such as the age of sitting up, teething, and walking. They also are alike in many psychological traits, such as overall vocabulary, creativity, intelligence, extraversion, and happiness. Women and men feel the same emotions and longings, both dote on their children, and they have similar-appearing brains. Indeed, noted Ethan Zell and his colleagues (2015) in their review of 106 meta-analyses (each a statistical digest of dozens of studies), the common result for most variables studied is gender similarity (Hyde, 2018). ***On most psychological attributes, the overlap between the sexes is larger than the difference*** (Carothers & Reis, 2013; Hyde, 2005). ***Your "opposite sex" is actually your similar sex.***

Yet of course there are also pronounced gender differences. Compared to males, the average female

- has 70% more fat, has 40% less muscle, is 5 inches shorter, and weighs 40 pounds less;
- is more sensitive to smells and sounds;
- is twice as likely to experience anxiety disorders or depression (Salk et al., 2017).

Compared to females, the average male is

- slower to enter puberty (by about 2 years) but ***quicker to die*** (by 4 years, worldwide);
- three times more likely to be diagnosed with ADHD (attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder), four times more likely to commit suicide, and five times more likely to be killed by lightning;
- more capable of wiggling his ears.

During the 1970s, many scholars worried that studies of such gender differences might reinforce stereotypes. Would gender differences be construed as women's deficits? Although the findings confirm some stereotypes of women — as less physically aggressive, more nurturing, and more socially sensitive — those traits are actually preferred by most people, whether male or female (Prentice & Carranza, 2002; Swim, 1994). Small wonder, then, that most people rate their beliefs and feelings regarding women as more favorable than their feelings regarding men — a phenomenon some have labeled the "women are wonderful" effect (Eagly, 1994; Haddock & Zanna, 1994).

As we discuss the **gender differences found in research**, keep in mind they **are differences based on averages; they do not apply to every member of the group**. Many of these differences may resonate with your own experiences. Others might not, but that doesn't necessarily mean they are incorrect. For example, despite being female, I [JT] am not particularly interested in shopping. So if a study found that women are more interested in shopping, I would be the exception. When I was younger, I didn't like reading about gender differences (such as in shopping) that made women look frivolous. Slowly, I started to realize that just because something was true of the average woman didn't mean it had to be true of me. For men, the equivalent might be reading about differences in undesirable acts such as aggression and violence; ***even if it's true on average, it doesn't have to be true of you***. Keep that in mind as you read.

Independence versus Connectedness

Individual men display outlooks and behavior that vary from fierce competitiveness to caring nurturance. So do individual women. Without denying that, several late-twentieth-century feminist psychologists contended that women more than

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men give priority to close, intimate relationships (Chodorow, 1978, 1989; Gilligan, 1982; Gilligan et al., 1990; Miller, 1986). Consider the evidence:

PLAY Compared to boys, girls talk more intimately and play less aggressively, noted Eleanor Maccoby (2002) from her decades of research on gender development. They also play in smaller groups, often talking with one friend. Boys more often engage in larger group activities (Rose & Rudolph, 2006). Even today, boys and girls strongly prefer to play with toys associated with their gender (Davis & Hines, 2020). And as boys play with boys and girls play with girls, sex differences grow larger. These sex differences in play among youngsters appear in nonhuman primates such as monkeys as well, suggesting fairly universal and perhaps biological roots (Lonsdorf, 2017).



Girls' play is often in small groups and imitates relationships. Boys' play is more often competitive or aggressive.
(Girls): FatCamera/Stock/Getty Images; (Boys): Fuse/Corbis RF/Getty Images

FRIENDSHIP AND PEER RELATIONSHIPS As adults, women — at least in individualistic cultures — are more likely than men to describe themselves in relational terms, experience relationship-linked emotions, value social goals, and be attuned to others' relationships (Gabriel & Gardner, 1999; Tamres et al., 2002; Vilar et al., 2020; Watkins et al., 1998, 2003; Yang & Girgus, 2019). On social media, women use more words about relationships ("friends," "family," "sister"), while men use more words about specific activities and ideas ("political," "football," "battle"); overall, women's language online is warmer, more compassionate, and more polite, while men's is colder, more hostile, and more impersonal (Park et al., 2016; Statista, 2019; Tifferet, 2020). On average, women are more aware of how their actions affect other people (You et al., 2011) and feel a closer attachment to their friends (Gorrese & Ruggieri, 2012). "Perhaps because of their greater desire for intimacy," reported Joyce Benenson and colleagues (2009), during their first year of college, women are twice as likely as men to change roommates.

Women's phone conversations last longer, and girls send more than twice as many text messages as do boys (Friebel & Seabright, 2011; Lenhart, 2010; Smoreda & Licoppe, 2000). Women talk for longer when the goal is affiliation with others — though men actually talk more overall and when the goal is asserting one's opinions and giving information (Leaper & Ayres, 2007). Women spend more time sending emails in which they express more emotion (Crabtree, 2002; Thomson & Murachver, 2001). Women and girls spend more time on social networking sites such as Instagram, while boys and men spend more time on electronic gaming (Twenge & Martin, 2020).

When in groups, women share more of their lives and offer more support (Dindia & Allen, 1992; Eagly, 1987). When facing stress, men tend to respond with "fight or flight"; often, their response to a threat is combat. In nearly all studies, noted Shelley Taylor (2002), women who are under stress more often "tend and befriend"; they turn to friends and family for support. Among first-year college students, 72% of men, but 83% of women, say it is very important to "help others who are in difficulty" (Stolzenberg et al., 2019). The sex difference in independence versus connectedness can readily be seen in a study of language use on Facebook (Schwartz et al., 2013; Figure 5).

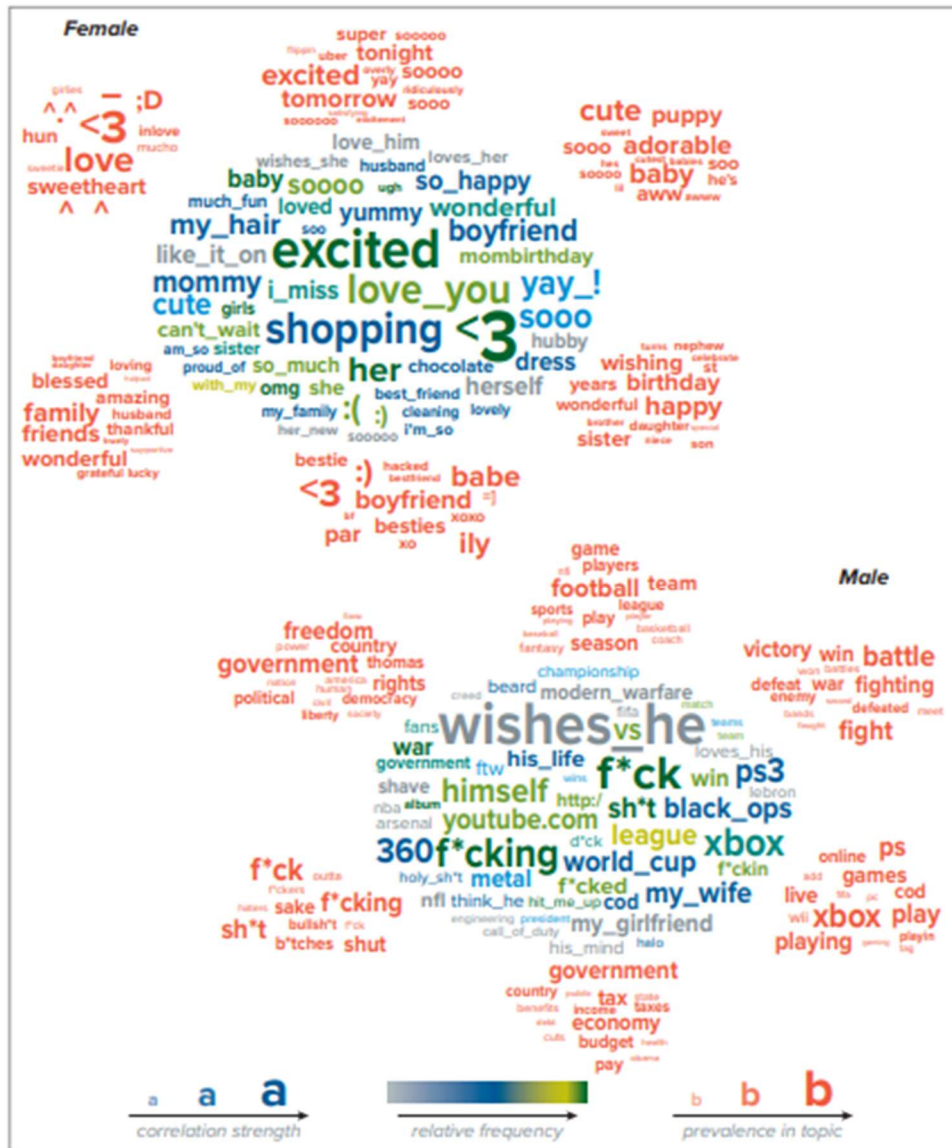


FIGURE 5
Words and phrases with the largest gender differences among more than 70,000 Facebook users

The gender difference in independence versus connectedness is readily apparent in this natural language study, as are other differences such as men's greater propensity to swear and women's greater focus on shopping. The red clusters show the specific topics with the largest gender differences.
Source: Schwartz, et al., (2013).

In writing, women tend to use more communal prepositions ("with"), fewer quantitative words, and more present tense. Men use more complex language and women use more social words and pronouns (Newman et al., 2008). One computer program, which taught itself to recognize gender differences in word usage and sentence structure, successfully identified the author's gender in 80% of 920 British fiction and nonfiction works (Koppel et al., 2002).

In conversation, men's style reflects their concern for independence, women's for connectedness. Men are more likely to act as powerful people often do: talking assertively, interrupting intrusively, touching with the hand, staring more, smiling less (Leaper & Robnett, 2011). On the U.S. Supreme Court, for example, women are disproportionately interrupted by their male colleagues (Jacobi & Schweers, 2017). Women's influence style tends to be more indirect: less interruptive, more sensitive, more polite, less cocky, and more qualified and hedged.

So is it right to declare (in the title words of one 1990s bestseller), *Men Are from Mars, Women Are from Venus*? Actually, noted Kay Deaux and Marianne LaFrance (1998), men's and women's conversational styles vary with the social context. Much of the style we attribute to men is typical of people (men and women) in positions of status and power (Hall et al., 2006; Pennebaker, 2011). For example, students nod more when speaking with professors than when speaking with peers,

and women not more than men (Helweg-Larsen et al., 2004). Men — and people in high-status roles — tend to talk louder and to interrupt more (Hall et al., 2005). Moreover, individuals vary; some men are hesitant, some women assertive. To suggest that women and men are from different planets greatly oversimplifies. Men and women are both from the Earth — though maybe from somewhat different places (New York and New Jersey? Beijing and Shanghai?)

VOCATIONS In general, women are more interested in jobs dealing with people (teachers, doctors) and men in jobs with things (truck driver, engineer) (Diekmann et al., 2010; Eagly, 2009, 2017; Lippa, 2010; Su et al., 2009). Females are less interested in math-intensive careers than are males, even among those with a talent for math (Lubinski & Benbow, 2006), and even though more girls than boys around the world appear capable of college-level math and science work (Stoet & Geary, 2018).

Another distinction: Men gravitate disproportionately to jobs that enhance inequalities (prosecuting attorney, corporate advertising); women gravitate to jobs that reduce inequalities (public defender, advertising work for a charity [Pratto et al., 1997]). Studies of 640,000 people's job preferences reveal that men more than women value earnings, promotion, challenge, and power; women more than men value good hours, personal relationships, and opportunities to help others (Konrad et al., 2000; Pinker, 2008). Indeed, in most of the North American caregiving professions, such as social worker, teacher, and nurse, women outnumber men. Recent decades have seen a few changes: Among Israeli young adults, men and women did not differ in their preferences for management careers in 2010 (versus 1990, when men preferred these careers), but men still preferred technical careers more than women did (Gati & Perez, 2014). As of 2012, 66% of U.S. young women agreed that being successful in a high-paying career was important — higher than the 59% of young men who agreed (Patten & Parker, 2012).

FAMILY RELATIONS Women's connections as mothers, daughters, sisters, and grandmothers bind families (Rossi & Rossi, 1990). Following their child's birth, parents (women especially) become more traditional in their gender-related attitudes and behaviors (Ferriman et al., 2009; Katz-Wise et al., 2010). Compared with men, women buy three times as many gifts and greeting cards, write two to four times as many personal letters, and make 10 to 20% more long-distance calls to friends and family (Putnam, 2000). Among 500 randomly selected Facebook pages around the world, women displayed more family photos and expressed more emotion, and men were more likely to display status or risk taking (Tiffert & Vilnai-Yavetz, 2014).

SMILING Smiling, of course, varies with situations. Yet across more than 400 studies, women's greater connectedness has been expressed in their generally higher rate of smiling (Fischer & LaFrance, 2015; LaFrance et al., 2003). For example, when Marianne LaFrance (1985) analyzed 9,000 college yearbook photos, she found females more often smiling. So did Amy Halberstadt and Martha Saitta (1987) in 1,100 magazine and newspaper photos and 1,300 people in shopping malls, parks, and streets. Apparently, boys learn not to smile as much by age 11: Boys and girls smile just as often in their elementary school pictures, but by sixth grade, girls smile significantly more than boys (Wondergem & Friedmeier, 2012). This does not appear to be due to gender differences in happiness: Men and women are equally satisfied with their lives (Batz-Barbarich et al., 2018).

EMPATHY When surveyed, women are far more likely to describe themselves as having *empathy*, or being able to feel what another feels — to rejoice with those who rejoice and weep with those who weep (Chopik et al., 2017; O'Brien et al., 2013). To a lesser extent, the empathy difference extends to laboratory studies:

- Shown pictures or told stories, girls react with more empathy (Hunt, 1990).
- Given upsetting experiences in the laboratory or in real life, women more than men express empathy for others enduring similar experiences (Batson et al., 1996).
- Observing someone receiving supposed painful shocks, women's empathy-related brain circuits display elevated activity when men's do not (Singer et al., 2006).

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All these differences help to explain why, compared with male friendships, both men and women report friendships with women to be more intimate, enjoyable, and nurturing (Rubin, 1985; Sapadin, 1988). When you want empathy and understanding, someone to whom you can disclose your joys and hurts, to whom do you turn? Most men and women usually turn to women.

One explanation for this male–female empathy difference is that **women tend to outperform men at reading others' emotions**. In her analysis of 125 studies of men's and women's sensitivity to nonverbal cues, Judith Hall (1984, 2006) discerned that women are generally superior at decoding others' emotional messages. For example, shown a 2-second silent film clip of the face of an upset woman, women guess more accurately whether she is criticizing someone or discussing her divorce. Women also are more often strikingly better than men at recalling others' appearance (Mast & Hall, 2006).

Finally, women are more skilled at expressing emotions nonverbally, said Hall. This is especially so for positive emotion, reported Erick Coats and Robert Feldman (1996). They had people talk about times they had been happy, sad, and angry. When shown 5-second silent video clips of happy reports, observers could much more accurately discern women's than men's emotions. Men, however, were slightly more successful in conveying anger.

Social Dominance

Imagine two people: One is “adventurous, autocratic, coarse, dominant, forceful, independent, and strong.” The other is “affectionate, dependent, dreamy, emotional, submissive, and weak.” If the first person sounds more to you like a man and the second like a woman, you are not alone, reported John Williams and Deborah Best (1990, p. 15). From Asia to Africa and Europe to Australia, people rate men as more dominant, driven, and aggressive. Moreover, studies of nearly 80,000 people across 70 countries show that men more than women rate power as important (Schwartz & Rubel, 2005).

These perceptions and expectations correlate with reality. In essentially every society, men are more socially dominant (Pratto, 1996). As Peter Hegarty and his colleagues (2010) have observed, across time, men's titles and names have come first: “King and Queen,” “his and hers,” “husband and wife,” “Mr. and Mrs.,” “Bill and Hillary.” Shakespeare never wrote plays with titles such as Juliet and Romeo or Cleopatra and Antony.

As we will see, gender differences vary greatly by culture, and gender differences are shrinking in many industrialized societies as women assume more managerial and leadership positions (Desilver, 2018; Koenig et al., 2011). However:

- In 2019 women were but 24% of the world's legislators (IPU, 2019).
- Men are more likely to favor conservative political candidates and programs that preserve group inequality (Eagly et al., 2004; Sidanius & Pratto, 1999).
- Men are half of all jurors but the vast majority of elected jury leaders; men are also the leaders of most ad hoc laboratory groups (Colarelli et al., 2006; Hastie et al., 2002).
- In Britain men hold 66% of top-100 corporate board positions — though that's down from 88% in 2011 (Austin, 2020).
- Women in most countries earn an average of 78% to 84% of men's wages, according to the World Bank. Less than one-tenth of this wage gap is attributable to gender differences in education, work experience, or job characteristics (World Bank, 2019).

Across many studies, people perceive *leaders* as having more culturally masculine traits — as being more confident, forceful, independent, and outspoken (Koenig et al., 2011). When writing letters of recommendation, people more often use such “agentic” adjectives when describing male candidates, and more “communal” adjectives (helpful, kind, sympathetic, nurturing, tactful) when describing women candidates (Madera et al., 2009). The net effect may be to disadvantage women applying for leadership roles. And when women do act in dominant ways, they are often seen as

less likable (Williams & Tiedens, 2016), creating another barrier. ***When a man speaks assertively, he is more likely to be seen as a leader, but not so for women*** (McClean et al., 2018).

Men's style of communicating undergirds their social power. In leadership roles, men tend to excel as directive, task-focused leaders; women excel more often in the "transformational" or "relational" leadership that is favored by more and more organizations, with inspirational and social skills that build team spirit (Pfaff et al., 2013). Men more than women place priority on winning, getting ahead, and dominating others (Sidanius et al., 1994). This may explain why people's preference for a male leader is greater for competitions between groups, such as when countries are at war, than when conflicts occur within a group (Van Vugt & Spisak, 2008).

Men's greater social power is not entirely positive, as they may fear losing it — a phenomenon known as ***precarious manhood*** (Kroeper et al., 2014; Vandello & Bosson, 2013). In many cultures, masculinity is seen as something that must be earned and defended. As Joseph Vandello and Jennifer Bosson point out, "We implore [men] to '**man up**' in the face of difficulties and we question whether someone is '**man enough**' for the job. . . . In contrast, one rarely if ever encounters questions about whether a woman is a '**real woman**' or '**woman enough**'" (2013, p. 101). Men are much more concerned about being identified as feminine than women are at being identified as masculine (Bosson & Michniewicz, 2013) — perhaps one reason why men are more likely than women to be prejudiced against gay men (Carnaghi et al., 2011; Glick et al., 2007). Men may also defend their masculinity when they have a female boss, acting more assertively than they do toward a male boss (Netchaeva et al., 2015).

Men also act more impulsively and take more risks (Byrnes et al., 1999; Cross et al., 2011; Petraitis et al., 2014), perhaps because ***they are trying to prove their masculinity*** (Parent et al., 2017). One study of data from 35,000 stockbroker accounts found that "men are more overconfident than women" and therefore made 45% more stock trades (Barber & Odean, 2001a). Because trading costs money and because men's trades proved no more successful, their results underperformed the stock market by 2.65%, compared with women's 1.72% underperformance. The men's trades were riskier — and the men were the poorer for it. Even in Finland, a country with high gender equality, men take more risks in their stock market holdings (Halko et al., 2012). Men and women do not differ, however, in taking social risks, such as expressing an unpopular opinion (Harris et al., 2006).

Aggression

By aggression, psychologists mean behavior intended to hurt. Throughout the world, hunting, fighting, and warring are primarily male activities (Wood & Eagly, 2007). In surveys, men admit to more aggression than women do. In laboratory experiments, men indeed exhibit more physical aggression, for example, by administering what they believe are hurtful electric shocks (Knight et al., 2002). In Canada and the United States, 8 times as many men as women are arrested for murder (Statistics Canada, 2010; FBI, 2017). Almost all suicide terrorists have been young men (Kruglanski & Golec de Zavala, 2005). So also are nearly all battlefield deaths and death-row inmates.

aggression

Physical or verbal behavior intended to hurt someone. In laboratory experiments, this might mean delivering supposed electric shocks or saying something likely to hurt another's feelings.

But again, the gender difference fluctuates with the context. When people are provoked, the gender gap shrinks (Bettencourt & Kernahan, 1997; Richardson, 2005). And within less assaultive forms of aggression — for instance, slapping a family member, throwing something, or verbally attacking someone — women are no less aggressive than men and may even be more aggressive (Archer, 2000; Björkqvist, 1994; White & Kowalski, 1994). Women are also slightly more likely to commit indirect aggressive acts, such as spreading malicious gossip (Archer, 2009). But all across the world and at all ages, men much more often injure others with physical aggression.

Sexuality

In their physiological and subjective responses to sexual stimuli, women and men are “more similar than different” (Griffitt, 1987). The differences lie in what happens beforehand. Consider the following:

- Imagine you are walking on campus one day when an attractive member of the other sex approaches you. “Hi, I’ve been noticing you around campus lately, and I find you very attractive. Would you have sex with me tonight?” he or she asks. What would you do? In one study, not a single woman said yes, and 3 out of 4 of the men said yes (Clark & Hatfield, 1989). When asked instead if they would go on a date, about half of both men and women said yes (Clark, 1990; Clark & Hatfield, 1989).
- “I can imagine myself being comfortable and enjoying ‘casual’ sex with different partners,” agreed 48% of men and 12% of women in an Australian survey (Bailey et al., 2000). One 48-nation study showed country-by-country variation in acceptance of unrestricted sexuality, ranging from relatively promiscuous Finland to relatively monogamous Taiwan (Schmitt, 2005). But in every country studied, men expressed more desire for unrestricted sex. More recent data suggest the difference has persisted, with men more approving of casual sex (Sprecher et al., 2013) and more likely to favor hookups without obligations (Weitbrecht & Whitton, 2020). These sex differences appear among gay men and lesbian women as well (Howard & Periloux, 2017).
- In a survey of 3,400 U.S. adults, half as many men (25%) as women (48%) cited affection for the partner as a reason for losing their virginity. Among 18- to 25-year-old college students, the average man thought about sex about once per hour, the average woman about once every 2 hours — though there was lots of individual variation (Fisher et al., 2011). Men also thought about food and sleep more than women, suggesting they might just think about all needs more (Fisher et al., 2012).

The gender difference in sexual attitudes carries over to behavior. “With few exceptions anywhere in the world,” reported cross-cultural psychologist Marshall Segall and his colleagues (1990, p. 244), ***“males are more likely than females to initiate sexual activity.”***

Compared with lesbians, gay men also report more interest in uncommitted sex, more frequent sex, more interest in pornography, more responsiveness to visual stimuli, and more concern with partner attractiveness (Peplau & Fingerhut, 2007; Rupp & Wallen, 2008; Schmitt, 2007). In the mid-2000s, 47% of U.S. lesbians were in committed relationships, double the rate for gay men, 24% (Doyle, 2005). “It’s not that gay men are oversexed,” observed Steven Pinker (1997). “They are simply men whose male desires bounce off other male desires rather than off female desires.”

Indeed, not only do men fantasize more about sex, have more permissive attitudes, and seek more partners, they also are more quickly aroused, desire sex more often, masturbate more frequently, use more pornography, are less successful at celibacy, refuse sex less often, take more risks, expend more resources to gain sex, and prefer more sexual variety (Baumeister et al., 2001; Baumeister & Vohs, 2004; Petersen & Hyde, 2011). Figure 6 displays the large gender difference in pornography use in one national survey (Carroll et al., 2017).

Another survey asked 16,288 people from 52 nations how many sexual partners they desired in the next month. Among the unattached, 29% of men and 6% of women wanted more than one partner (Schmitt, 2003, 2005). These results were identical for straight and gay people (29% of gay men and 6% of lesbians desired more than one partner).

“Everywhere sex is understood to be something females have that males want,” offered anthropologist Donald Symons (1979, p. 253). Small wonder, said Roy Baumeister and Kathleen Vohs, that cultures everywhere attribute greater value to female than male sexuality, as indicated in gender asymmetries in prostitution and courtship, where men generally offer money, gifts, praise, or commitment in implicit exchange for a woman’s sexual engagement. In human sexual economics, they noted, women rarely if ever pay for sex. Like labor unions opposing “scab labor” as undermining the value of their own work, most women oppose other women offering “cheap sex,” which reduces the value of their own sexuality.

Across 185 countries, the fewer the available men, the higher is the teen pregnancy rate — because when men are scarce, **“women compete against each other by offering sex at a lower price in terms of commitment”** (Barber, 2000; Baumeister & Vohs, 2004; Moss & Maner, 2016). Men are scarce on many college campuses these days (where they are only 43% of students); perhaps that’s why more campuses now have social norms favoring uncommitted hookups (Olmstead, 2020; Wade, 2017). In contrast, where women are scarce, as is increasingly the case in China and India, the market value of their sexuality rises, and they are able to command greater commitment.

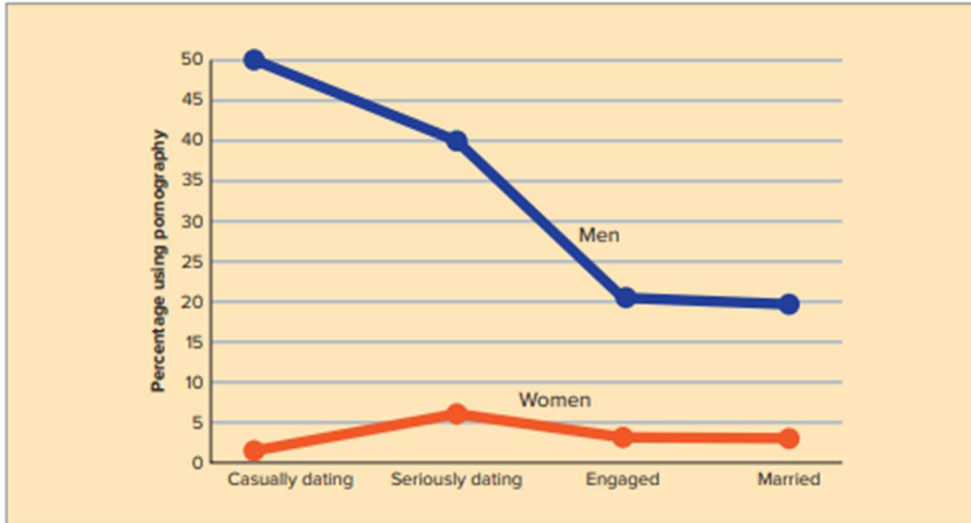


FIGURE 6

The pornography gap.
A large national survey of heterosexual couples found a substantial gender gap in pornography consumption.

Source: Carroll, J. S., Busby, D. M., Willoughby, B. J., & Brown, C. C. (2017).

Sexual fantasies, too, differ between men and women (Ellis & Symons, 1990). In male-oriented erotica, women are unattached and lust driven. In romance novels, primarily read by women, a strong male is emotionally consumed by his devoted passion for the heroine. Social scientists aren’t the only ones to have noticed. “Women can be fascinated by a four-hour movie with subtitles wherein the entire plot consists of a man and a woman yearning to have, but never actually having a relationship,” observed humorist Dave Barry (1995). **“Men HATE that. Men can take maybe 45 seconds of yearning, and they want everybody to get naked. Followed by a car chase. A movie called ‘Naked People in Car Chases’ would do really well among men.”**

Just as police detectives are more intrigued by crime than virtue, so psychological detectives are more intrigued by differences than similarities. Let us therefore remind ourselves: **Individual differences far exceed gender differences.** Females and males are hardly “opposite” sexes. Rather, they differ like two folded hands — similar but not the same, fitting together yet differing as they grasp each other.

WHAT CAN WE CONCLUDE ABOUT GENES, CULTURE, AND GENDER?

We needn’t think of biology and culture as competitors. Cultural norms subtly yet powerfully affect our attitudes and behavior. But they don’t do so independent of biology. **Everything social and psychological is ultimately biological.** If others’ expectations influence us, that is part of our biological programming. Moreover, **what our biological heritage initiates, culture may accentuate.** Genes and hormones predispose males to be more physically aggressive than females. But culture amplifies that difference through norms that expect males to be tough and females to be the kinder, gentler sex. (When explaining gender differences, women more than men point to such social influences [Pew Research Center, 2017].)

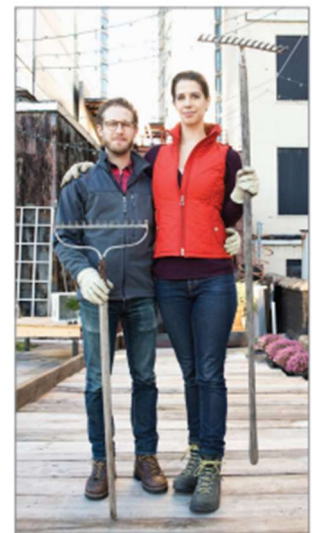
Biology and culture may also **interact**. Advances in genetic science indicate how experience uses genes to change the brain (Carlson et al., 2015; Quartz & Sejnowski, 2002). Environmental stimuli can activate genes that produce new brain cell-branching receptors. Visual experience activates genes that develop the brain’s visual area. Parental touch activates genes

that help offspring cope with future stressful events. ***Genes are not set in stone; they respond adaptively to our experiences.***

As we mentioned earlier in the chapter, the field of **epigenetics** (meaning “in addition to” genetics) explores the mechanisms by which environments trigger genetic expression. Diet, drugs, and stress, including child abuse, can all regulate gene expression (Champagne & Mashoodh, 2009; McGowan et al., 2010; Yang et al., 2013). Animal studies suggest that epigenetic changes can be passed down through several generations. When pregnant females are exposed to toxins or unhealthy diets, for example, the effects are seen not just in the babies but in their offspring as well (the “grandchildren”) (de Assis et al., 2012). Thus far, studies on humans have focused more on how the environment changes genetic tendencies. For example, in families who fight frequently, the genetic prediction of anxiety is reduced because everyone is anxious. But when families are fairly calm, only those more genetically prone to anxiety are anxious, so genetics have more influence (Jang et al., 2005). Overall, the science of epigenetics suggests that environmental factors shape lifelong biological changes, showing that nature and nurture work together — not independently.

Biology and experience also interact when biological traits influence how the environment reacts. Men, being 8% taller and averaging almost double the proportion of muscle mass, are bound to experience life differently from women. Or consider this: A strong cultural norm dictates that males should be taller than their female mates, and thus the man is taller than the woman in more couples than would be expected by chance (Stulp et al., 2013). With hindsight, we can speculate a psychological explanation: Perhaps being taller helps men perpetuate their social power over women. But we can also speculate evolutionary wisdom that might underlie the cultural norm: If people preferred partners of their own height, tall men and short women would often be without partners. As it is, evolution dictates that men tend to be taller than women, and culture dictates the same for couples. So the height norm might well be a result of biology and culture.

Alice Eagly (2009, 2017) and Wendy Wood (Eagly & Wood, 2013; Wood & Eagly, 2007) theorize how biology and culture interact (Figure 7). They believe that a variety of factors, including biological influences and childhood socialization, predispose a sexual division of labor. In adult life, the immediate causes of gender differences in social behavior are the roles that reflect this sexual division of labor. Men, because of their biologically endowed strength and speed, tend to be found in roles demanding physical power. Women’s capacity for childbearing and breastfeeding inclines them to more nurturant roles. Each sex then tends to exhibit the behaviors expected of those who fill such roles and to have their skills and beliefs shaped accordingly. Nature and nurture are a “tangled web.” As role assignments become more equal, Eagly predicts that gender differences “will gradually lessen.”



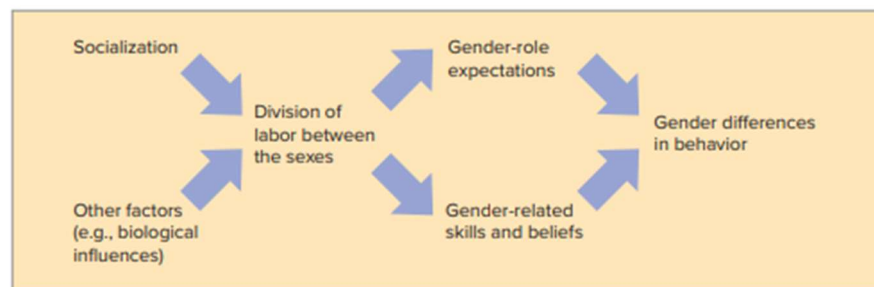
It is still unusual to see a couple in which the woman is taller than the man. That might be due to biology, culture, or most likely, both.
Jasper Cole/Blend Images/Getty Images

FIGURE 7

A Social-Role Theory of Gender Differences in Social Behavior

Various influences, including childhood experiences and factors, bend males and females toward differing roles. It is the expectations and the skills and beliefs associated with these differing roles that affect men’s and women’s behavior.

Source: Adapted from Eagly, A. (1987).



Indeed, note Eagly and Wood, in cultures with greater equality of gender roles, the gender difference in mate preferences (men seeking youth and domestic skill, women seeking status and earning potential) is less. Likewise, as women's employment in formerly male occupations has increased, the gender difference in self-reported assertiveness has decreased (Twenge, 1997). As men and women enact more similar roles, some psychological differences shrink — though they may not disappear (see “The Inside Story: Alice Eagly on Gender Similarities and Differences”).

THE **inside** STORY

Alice Eagly on Gender Similarities and Differences

I began my research on gender in the early 1970s. Like many feminist psychologists of the day, I initially assumed that, despite cultural gender stereotypes, women and men are generally equivalent in their psychology and social behavior. Over the years, my views have evolved considerably. I have found that that some social behaviors do differ between women and men, especially in situations in which gender norms become salient. Also, women and men differ substantially when scientists step back from the specifics of narrowly defined psychological variables and instead examine general themes in the psychology of women and men. In particular, women tend to manifest more communion than men do — that is, warmth and concern for others; men tend to manifest more agency than women do — that is, dominance and competitiveness.

People should not assume that these thematic differences reflect unfavorably on women. Instead, these

tendencies to be more attuned to others' concerns are generally admired and can be assets in many situations and roles. In fact, the female stereotype is in general more positive than the male stereotype. However, the qualities of niceness and nurturance that are important in expectations about women can decrease their power and effectiveness in situations that call for assertive and competitive behavior. Women's awareness of this pitfall can foster innovative approaches to exerting influence without necessarily enacting typically masculine behaviors.

Alice Eagly
Northwestern University
Courtesy of Alice Eagly



But not all gender differences have shrunk, report David Schmitt and his international colleagues (2008, 2016). Across 55 nations, women report more extraversion, agreeableness, and conscientiousness. These gender differences are greatest in (surprise!) prosperous, educated, egalitarian countries. In less fortunate economic and social contexts, suggests Schmitt, “the development of one's inherent personality traits is more restrained.”

Although biology predisposes men to strength tasks and women to infant care, Wood and Eagly (2002) concluded that **“the behavior of women and men is sufficiently malleable that individuals of both sexes are fully capable of effectively carrying out organizational roles at all levels.”** For today's high-status and often high-tech work roles, male size and aggressiveness matter little. Moreover, lower birthrates mean that women are less constrained by pregnancy and nursing. The end result, when combined with competitive pressures for employers to hire the best talent regardless of gender, is greater gender equality.

CONCLUDING THOUGHTS: Should We View Ourselves as Products of Our Biology or Our Culture?

In considering whether biology or culture has the strongest influence on us, ***we might be asking the wrong question.*** Instead, we can consider how biology and culture work together to create who we are. Especially with the new science of epigenetics, the question is increasingly not nature versus nurture as if they were two teams playing against each other, but ***nature and nurture as one team working together to shape us.***

That is particularly true for differences between men and women. Sex differences may begin in the biological demands of being male or female, but they do not end there. Culture takes biological sex differences and molds them into both culturally universal and culturally distinct gender roles and expectations. Even in an era of more gender equality and an increasing focus on gender fluidity, gender — like biology and culture — still influences us.

Source:

Myers, David & Twenge, Jean(2022). Social Psychology 14th Edition. NY, McGraw-Hill Companies, Inc. 139-168